

Theory of Religion By Emile Durkheim

Theory Of Religion

Durkheim evolved a functional explanation for the existence of religion in the world.

He observed its existence as a social fact and not as a supernatural phenomenon.

He gave the idea of religion in his work, Elementary Forms Of Religious Life 1912.

Societyopedia

Definition by DURKHEIM

Religion – A unified system of beliefs and practices related to sacred things, that is to say – things set apart and forbidden, beliefs and practices, which you need them into a single moral community, for all those who adhere to them.

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EXPLANATION OF THE DEFINITION

Beliefs – A unified system of ideas which explain the sacred, they constitute of myths, spiritual ideas, ethical code, etc.

Practices – Rites or rituals explaining individuals behaviour towards the sacred.

Positive rites – Bring individual and sacred together and are easier to perform, like worship.

Negative rites – Help in maintaining the distance between the two (individual and sacred) and keep them separated, for example, fasting and sacrifice.

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SACRED AND PROFANE

Society consists of two parts – the sacred and the profane.

The Sacred

- Things which are set apart and are forbidden.
- It includes all things which are connected to the supernatural or the divine.
- Relationship of distance and fear is maintained with the respect to these things.

Profane

- Profane are the things apart from the sacred.
- Includes day-to-day things which people use in their lives.

TOTEMISM

In this, totems are worshipped.

Totem is a representation of the clan itself.

He drew his analysis from the study of religious practices among Arunta, the Australian aboriginals.

Primitive men, when they came together for some purpose like festivals and interacted on such occasions, they felt the energy of social force.

According to primitive logic, they explain this feeling in terms of presence of some supernatural force.

Durkheim calls this height and feeling of energy generated in collective gatherings as state of exaltation or collective effervescence.

These higher forces are deemed as divine or supernatural and attributed to certain totems by the primitive tribes.

They create a totem to represent and regain that feeling.

The totems are the material representations of the non-material force that is at their base and that non-material force is none other than the society itself.

The feeling which was due to the feeling of being together, was instead, interpreted as The Sacred. So, totem is a symbol of collectivity or the symbol of society itself.

Origin of Religion

Primitive People
were wanders



Occasionally came
Together



Need to experience
that feeling



State of Exaltation



Creation of totem



Root cause of
religion

Religion And Society

Durkheim asks 'If it is at once the symbol of God and Society, is it not because God and Society are one and same'?

Religious experiences are real experiences of social forces, forces that unite us.

Social obligations are represented in sacred terms and hence transform into religious duties. Eg: Marriage becomes a sacrament.

Religion is also a social fact.

It performs the function of bringing people together.

Criticism

- The dichotomy of profane and sacred is not absolute and there can be 'things' also as per William Edward Stanner.
- Durkheim did not explain why a particular totem is chosen.
- Criticized for being an armchair theory.
- Generalisation of primitive religion to modern sophisticated religion is a farfetched view.
- Scholars argue that it is not religion but secularism which is binding the societies together in modern industrialised societies.
- Fails to explain the cause of solidarity in multicultural polytheistic societies like India.
- Focused only on functional aspects and ignored the conflict caused by religion.